

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ESWATINI

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the land and homesteads of Eswatini — but this guide must begin with unusual honesty and unusual caution, because Eswatini is among the hardest and most dangerous places in this whole series to oppose a project, and there is no grassroots victory to point to. Eswatini is an absolute monarchy: the King has reigned since 1986, the Parliament and the judiciary are subservient to the throne, most of the land is Swazi Nation Land vested in the King in trust and allocated by chiefs who owe their allegiance to him, and ordinary people have little security of tenure and little democratic voice. When a community's land is taken — for a plantation, a mine, a foreign investor's project, or simply because a landowner or authority reclaims it — residents' legal challenges are, in the words of human-rights monitors, shuffled endlessly between ministries, chiefdoms, and courts, and families face eviction with nowhere to go. And when Swazis have taken to the streets, as in the pro-democracy protests that began in June 2021, the state has answered with lethal force — with shootings, beatings, and, monitors reported, deaths. This guide will not pretend a safe or easy path exists where it does not.

The Eswatini story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly and up front. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the evidence, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly Swazi, and it is what gives this guide its real, if narrow, force. **Because the domestic institutions — the Parliament, the courts, and the chiefs — all answer, in the end, to the crown, and because open dissent is dangerous, a community's realest leverage is external: the regional and international human-rights bodies, the courts where they still function, and international pressure — reached carefully, with safety foremost.** That combination — documentation of the harm, the courts where they can act, and above all the African Commission and the other regional and international bodies — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because Swazi communities have actually used it, taking their evictions to the African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights.

But the same story carries an honest warning this guide places first and takes with the utmost seriousness, because here the danger is not abstract. **Opposition in Eswatini can be met with violence.** The 2021 protests were met with live fire; activists face harassment, detention, and physical abuse; pro-democracy figures have been arrested and driven into exile; and even plantation workers travelling to a protest were, monitors reported, stopped and beaten. Land tenure is insecure, the institutions are subservient to the throne, and the space for open opposition is minimal and hazardous. The honest record is one of evictions that proceed, protests met with force, and legal challenges endlessly delayed — not of communities stopping projects. This guide does not pretend the path is safe, easy, or likely to succeed. What it shows is how, in an absolute monarchy where domestic channels are captured and dangerous, a community can use the external levers — the human-rights bodies, the surviving courts, international pressure — to seek protection, redress, and accountability, while protecting its people above all else.

Most communities do not know HOW to reach the external bodies that can still hear them when the domestic institutions cannot. They face an eviction or a project and assume "the chief and the crown have

decided and there is nothing and no one to appeal to," and never document the harm, never reach the courts that still function, never petition the African Commission or the regional bodies, never connect with the human-rights networks and the diaspora who can carry the case to safer ground. They endure in isolation — or risk exposed protest that force will crush. The gap between families protected and families dispossessed is here often not apathy but a lack of method, a lack of safe channels, and a lack of knowledge of the external bodies that remain.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Eswatini system as it is, honestly, including its real dangers and its minimal space. It is written for the person whose land, homestead, or livelihood is threatened by a project, an investor, or an eviction, and who wants to know whether anyone can still be appealed to in an absolute monarchy where dissent is dangerous. The answer is a heavily qualified yes: the external levers exist, the human-rights bodies and the surviving courts are real, and communities have reached them — but the domestic space is captured and hazardous, the risks are grave, and there is no victory to promise you, only protection to seek, redress to pursue, and accountability to demand, as safely as the hard conditions allow. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it must be used. It is for the person willing to work patiently, lawfully, externally, and above all safely — to document rather than to march, to file in court and petition a rights body rather than to confront the crown, to protect their people rather than to expose them. That is not a lesser form of courage but, in an absolute monarchy that has met dissent with live fire, the only form that does not risk lives, and the only one this guide can responsibly recommend. Anyone imagining that opposition here means a defiant public campaign should understand that such campaigns have been met with death, and that the real, reachable, survivable leverage lies elsewhere — in the courts that still function and the world beyond the borders. This guide is an honest map of that leverage, and of how a community can reach it while keeping its people alive.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to resist an eviction, a plantation, a mine, or a foreign investor's project:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the project, the harm, and the deciders)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION          (build the evidence -- rights and harm)
      |
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION       (build the community, carefully and safely)
      |
STEP 4: LEGAL, CUSTOMARY & INTERNATIONAL (courts, land system, rights bodies)
      |
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY         (raise it, especially beyond the borders)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of harm and rights violation feeds the courts, the human-rights bodies, and the international networks at once; the community organises, carefully; a court filing or a petition to the African Commission is both protection and a spur to the next. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still narrow and hazardous — chance of protection and redress in a system where such outcomes are rare.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Eswatini's — an absolute monarchy whose institutions are captured, but which sits within a region and a world of human-rights bodies and watching neighbours — give communities a distinctive, if external, set:

- **The African Commission.** The **African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights** can hear a community that its own captured institutions will not, as Swazi communities' engagement over evictions

has shown.

- **The surviving courts.** The **courts**, subservient though the system is, still hear land and eviction challenges, however delayed — a real if uncertain channel.
- **International pressure. Donors, trade preferences, and the region** — the AU, SADC, the Commonwealth, the EU, and Eswatini's neighbours — apply pressure the crown feels.
- **The diaspora and solidarity.** The **large Swazi diaspora and regional solidarity networks**, especially in South Africa, can carry a case to safer ground.
- **Documentation and the world's eye. Credible documentation of rights violations**, carried abroad, is a lever the domestic system cannot suppress.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers reliably work, or that any victory awaits, and dangerous to promise safety. There is **no grassroots win** in Eswatini; protest has been met with **lethal force**; the institutions are **subservient to the crown**; tenure is **insecure**; and open opposition is **minimal and hazardous**. This guide takes those limits with deadly seriousness — it states them first and throughout, and it places safety above every other consideration — and shows how to use the real, distinctive tools this system still offers — the external human-rights bodies, the surviving courts, and international pressure — to seek protection and redress where victory is rare and danger is real.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must also see clearly where the danger lies. Before you spend a single week, and before you take a single risk, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the leverage is real and the risk is lowest. And map what would be lost and where the courts, the land system, the human-rights bodies, and international pressure apply, because in Eswatini a destructive project or an eviction is rarely stopped by domestic protest, which can be deadly, and is best resisted through the courts where they function and, above all, through the external human-rights bodies that can hear what the captured domestic institutions will not.

The Levels of Decision

An Eswatini development or eviction runs through several tracks, most of them answering to the crown, and the community's task is to find the few that can still be reached.

The crown and the traditional authorities. The **King, the government, and the chiefs** hold decisive power over land and projects; Swazi Nation Land is vested in the King in trust and allocated by chiefs loyal to him. They are the deciders — and, honestly, the hardest to move by domestic means.

The courts. The **courts**, subservient though the system is, still hear **land and eviction cases**, however delayed and shuffled between ministries, chiefdoms, and courts; they remain a real, if uncertain, domestic channel.

The African Commission and regional bodies. The **African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights**, and the AU and SADC, can hear a community's case and apply external pressure the crown cannot simply silence, as Swazi communities' engagement over evictions has shown.

International pressure. Donors, trade partners, the Commonwealth, the EU, and neighbouring states hold leverage — aid, trade preferences, reputation — that reaches the crown from outside.

The diaspora, unions, and civil society. The **Swazi diaspora, the unions, and the constrained civil society** are levers, however harassed at home, and can carry a case to safer ground abroad.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project or eviction moves from a decision by the crown, the government, or a chief — or a foreign investor's arrival — through the taking of land, toward the dispossession or the development, with the **community's evidence, the courts, the human-rights bodies, and international pressure** able to intervene, most realistically through the courts and the external bodies. **The courts and the African Commission are the channels that can still hear you**, and reaching them, safely, is the distinctive Swazi approach. The distinctive levers are the **surviving courts, the African Commission and regional bodies, international pressure**, and the **diaspora and solidarity networks**. Find out exactly where the matter stands, and, crucially, **what harm and rights violation would occur, which court or body can still hear it, and how to reach them safely**, because those are the few points where protection or redress can still be sought.

Follow the Project, the Land, and the Deciders

Behind a project or eviction stand the crown, the government, a chief, or a foreign investor. Trace who decides, who benefits, and — importantly here — **what harm and what rights violation would occur, whether the courts can still hear it, which human-rights bodies apply, and who abroad can help carry the case**. Two questions unlock most Eswatini efforts: **What harm and rights violation would be done, and who can still be appealed to?** and **Through which channel — the courts, the African Commission, international pressure — can protection or redress be sought, safely?** The external human-rights bodies and the surviving courts are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in an Eswatini effort ultimately serves these two: the documentation exists to prove a rights violation to a court or the African Commission, the coalition exists to carry that violation safely to those forums, and the media exists to amplify it before the international audience those forums answer to. Keep the courts and the external rights bodies at the center of every filing, letter, and appeal, and the effort retains a clear, external, and survivable spine even when its individual moves are modest and its domestic space is captured and dangerous.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can still check the deciders, because they are the community's levers. The **courts**, where they function; the **African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights** and the regional and continental bodies; the **international donors, trade partners, and neighbours**; the **human-rights monitors** — Amnesty, the ICJ, and others — whose documentation carries weight abroad; the **unions and constrained civil society**; and the **diaspora and solidarity networks**. In Eswatini, the **surviving courts, the African Commission, international pressure, and the diaspora** are the most distinctive levers, and the strongest of them lie outside the crown's reach. Each is a separate front, and a harm documented, taken to a court that can still hear it or to a human-rights body abroad, and amplified by international pressure, can sometimes win protection or redress — as communities engaging the African Commission over evictions have sought — though, honestly, the projects and evictions have usually proceeded, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep insisting on safety.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort — or take any risk — calibrate honestly, and here that means acknowledging that success is rare, that domestic protest can be deadly, and that the strongest levers lie outside the country. These figures are **directional and deliberately sober** — patterns drawn from how land and rights conflicts have mostly gone under this system, not a controlled study, and not a promise. The decisive variables are whether the community can **document the harm and the rights violation credibly**, whether it can **reach the courts and the external human-rights bodies** the captured domestic system cannot suppress, and whether it can **do so safely**. Where the harm is provable and the external bodies are engaged, the levers are real; but temper every figure with the honest, grave knowledge that protest has been met with lethal force, tenure is insecure, the institutions answer to the crown, and the space is minimal.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5–15%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Rights & harm case	25–45%	weeks–months	low	The violation, shown to those who can act
The courts (land/eviction)	20–40%	months–years	low–moderate	A delay, an order, rarely a stop
African Commission / regional	25–45%	months–years	low	External findings and pressure
International pressure	25–45%	months–years	low	Donor, trade, and reputational leverage
Diaspora & solidarity	20–40%	ongoing	low	Amplification and safer ground
All steps (documented, external)	25–45%	months–years	moderate	Protection, delay, redress, rarely a stop
Domestic protest alone	5–15%	days–weeks	grave risk	Often lethal force; seldom a win

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Eswatini's real strengths are the **external** ones: the **African Commission and regional bodies, international pressure, the diaspora, and the surviving courts**. Its constraints are specific, honest, and grave: **protest has been met with lethal force, tenure is insecure, the institutions answer to the crown, and the space is minimal** — and there is **no grassroots win** to build on.

*A note on cost and risk: the external levers here — a documented case, a court filing, a petition to the African Commission, an appeal to a solidarity network — cost mainly knowledge and persistence rather than money, and, crucially, some can be pursued more safely than domestic protest, which has been met with live fire. The scarce resources are **strategic knowledge of the external bodies, the courage to use them, and above all the ability to do so safely** — not funds. Reaching a court that still functions or a human-rights body abroad is worth more here than any domestic protest, and is far less likely to get someone killed. This is the plainest and most important calculation in the guide, and it should govern every decision: a channel that reaches a decision-maker beyond the crown's reach, and does so without exposing anyone to the security forces, is worth incomparably more than a visible gesture that risks lives for little leverage. The families of those killed in 2021 did not choose to become martyrs; they were met with force for a public stand. A community that internalises this will instinctively reach for the lawyer, the monitor, the Commission, and the diaspora before the street — not out of fear, but out of a clear-eyed understanding of*

where its power actually lies and how its people can be kept safe while that power is used.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (protection, redress, or -- rarely -- a project stopped)

DOCUMENTED HARM + EXTERNAL BODIES + SURVIVING COURTS:

All steps combined: ■■■■■■■■■■ 25-45%

Rights & harm case: ■■■■■■■■■■ 25-45%

African Commission route: ■■■■■■■■■■ 25-45%

International pressure: ■■■■■■■■■■ 25-45%

Single step: ■■ 5-45%

DOMESTIC-ONLY, IN AN ABSOLUTE MONARCHY -- captured, dangerous:

All steps combined: ■■■■■ 10-20%

Delay / protection / redress: ■■■■■■ sometimes achievable

The record / the case made: ■■■■■■■■■■ far more reliable than a stop

Domestic protest alone: ■ 5-15% and can be lethal

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Eswatini are the **external** ones — the African Commission and regional bodies, international pressure, the diaspora, and the surviving courts — while domestic protest alone is both perilous and usually futile. The reach of the external bodies shows the ceiling: a captured domestic system cannot silence a case heard by the African Commission or amplified by the region and the donors. The lethal repression of the 2021 protests shows the honest, terrible floor: domestic protest, unshielded by external leverage, was met with live fire and death. Most Eswatini efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the external levers are real and worth using — able to win protection, delay, redress, external findings, and rarely a stop — but that against a crown-controlled project or eviction, the realistic outcome is protection or a record, not a stop, and that domestic protest carries the gravest danger.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The rights and harm case** — Eswatini's foundation; the documented violation the external bodies and courts can act on.
2. **The African Commission and regional bodies** — the distinctive lever; the external forum that hears what the crown's institutions will not.
3. **International pressure** — the donor, trade, and reputational leverage the crown feels from outside.
4. **The surviving courts** — the uncertain but real domestic channel for land and eviction cases.
5. **The diaspora and solidarity networks** — amplification, safer ground, and protection.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest, sobering patterns recur. **The external bodies are the real levers** — communities have taken evictions to the African Commission when domestic institutions failed them. **Domestic protest is dangerous and can be lethal** — the 2021 protests were met with live fire. **The courts are uncertain and slow** — land challenges are shuffled and delayed for years. **Redress and protection are likelier than a stop** — a delay, an order, an external finding can sometimes be won. **There is no grassroots victory** — none, honestly, to point to. The through-line: **document the harm and the rights violation credibly; reach the courts that still function and the external bodies — the African Commission, the region, the donors — the captured system cannot suppress; protect your people above all — because a community that does can sometimes win protection, delay, and redress, while being honest that domestic protest can be deadly, the odds are hard, and there is no precedent of a community stopping a project.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project, eviction, and harm that govern the threat — and the leverage the community holds, which here is above all the external bodies and the surviving courts. Vague grievance goes nowhere, and unshielded domestic protest can be deadly; an effort aimed at "the eviction of these families from Swazi Nation Land without adequate process or alternative, which violates their rights, which the courts might delay or halt, and which the African Commission has heard in comparable cases" is a strategic, and safer, effort — the kind that can still be heard. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

- 1. What harm and rights violation would occur?** This is the first question here. What **harm and violation of rights** — a forced eviction without process or alternative, a project's environmental and community harm, a foreign investor's land seizure, as documented in communities like Velezizweni and Ntondozi.
- 2. Who decides, and who benefits?** Which **authority — the crown, the government, a chief, a foreign investor** — is behind it, and who benefits, since this shapes which levers apply.
- 3. Can the courts still hear it?** Whether the **courts** can hear a land or eviction challenge, however delayed, and what that would require.
- 4. Which external bodies apply?** Which of the **African Commission, the regional and continental bodies, the donors, and the human-rights monitors** can hear the case and apply pressure, as communities have engaged the African Commission on evictions.
- 5. How can this be done safely?** Given the record of lethal force, **how can the effort proceed without exposing its people** — through documentation, courts, and external bodies rather than dangerous protest.

A Worked Example

Suppose families face eviction from land they have long held, without adequate process or any alternative place to go.

Working the five questions: **what harm and rights violation? Who decides and benefits? Can the courts hear it? Which external bodies apply?** And, always, **how can this be done safely?** The deciders are the authority behind the eviction, with the courts, the African Commission, international pressure, and the diaspora as the channels.

Within a season you have moved from "the chief and the crown have decided and there is no appeal" to a strategy that still has channels: document the harm and the rights violation; file in the courts where possible; take the case to the African Commission and the human-rights monitors; enlist international and diaspora pressure — all while protecting the families from exposure. That is a strategic, safety-first effort suited to Eswatini — not a dangerous protest that force could meet with violence. Notice what the five questions accomplish: they convert a raw sense of helplessness and danger — the crown and the chief have decided, and to resist openly is to risk one's life — into a set of specific, answerable, and largely external targets, each attached to a lever that lies beyond the crown's reach and away from the line of fire. The harm becomes documentable evidence. The rights violation becomes a matter for a court and the African Commission. The channels become specific external bodies to petition. And the safety question, asked at every step, keeps the effort from tipping into the exposed confrontation that has been met with death. That translation — from dangerous, futile grievance into a strategic, protected, external campaign — is the first and most important thing a Swazi effort must do, because it moves the fight from ground where the

community is both weak and endangered to ground where it has real, reachable leverage and its people are safe.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, where the strongest case is made to courts and external human-rights bodies, sound, rights-referenced evidence is decisive. A judge, an African Commission, a human-rights monitor, and an international donor all move on documented rights violations, not on grievance — and in Eswatini, a clear record of the harm and of the rights it violates is precisely what an effort turns into external leverage, so build it well, and safely. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Eviction, and the Deciders

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project or eviction, the authority behind it, the land and homesteads it would take, and the process — or lack of process — followed**; and establish the **tenure situation** — Swazi Nation Land held in trust, title-deed land, the chief's role — and whether due process, alternatives, and court orders were observed, since forced evictions without these violate rights. Establish the deciders and the process precisely, because the distinctive case here is not merely that harm is done, but that it is done in violation of rights the courts and the African Commission can recognise.

Layer 2: The Harm and the Rights Violation

Document the harm and the violation, thoroughly and safely. Establish the **community harm** — the families dispossessed, the homes and livelihoods lost, the lack of any alternative, the disproportionate burden on widows and women and child-headed households that monitors have found — and, where a project is involved, the **environmental harm** — to land, water, and health. Then measure it against **rights** — the constitutional and international rights to housing, property, due process, and a healthy environment that forced evictions and unassessed projects violate. Gather it carefully, protecting those who provide it, in a state that has harassed and abused those who speak. Photographs, testimony, eviction notices, and expert and monitor reports make the harm and the violation undeniable — and, measured against rights, actionable before courts and the African Commission.

Layer 3: The Harm, the Rights, the Channel, and Safety

Finally, document the case and the plan. Does the **harm** violate **rights** the courts and external bodies recognise? Which **channel** — the courts, the African Commission, the monitors, international pressure — is open, and what does it require? And, always and above all, **how can this be done safely**, protecting people from a state that has met dissent with force? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that can be pressed before the courts and the external bodies where a captured system can still be reached from outside. This is the layer that most often decides what can be decided here, because a documented harm, a demonstrable rights violation, an open external channel, and a safe way to use it are exactly what give a Swazi community leverage its own institutions deny it. Build it well, and the rights the system violates become the community's strongest lever. One practical note on building this layer: the whole strategy depends on framing the harm precisely as a violation of recognised rights, because a court and the African Commission act on rights breached, not on hardship alone. A forced eviction is powerful evidence not merely because it is cruel but because it breaches specific rights — to adequate housing, to property, to due process, to a remedy — often carried out without a lawful order, without consultation, and without any alternative accommodation, each of which is a distinct, documentable failing. Establish which rights are

engaged, and document precisely how each was violated: no notice, no hearing, no order, no alternative, disproportionate impact on the vulnerable. That precision is what transforms a community's suffering, which a captured system can ignore, into a rights violation that a court can enjoin and the African Commission must consider — and it is the single most important thing this layer must get right.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists. Here is where the material tends to live in an Eswatini effort, and how to get it — with the **harm**, the **rights violation**, and the **courts and external bodies** at the center, and with safety a constant, overriding concern. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Project, Eviction, and Tenure Record

Start with the matter itself. **Eviction notices, project permits, and any court or administrative records** establish what is intended and what process was followed. Establish the **tenure situation** — whether the land is Swazi Nation Land held in trust and allocated by a chief, or title-deed land — and whether due process, alternatives, and lawful orders were observed, since forced evictions without these are the clearest violations. Establish exactly **what the project or eviction is, who is behind it, and what process was or was not followed**, because a rights violation of process is often the community's strongest legal and external handle.

The Harm and Rights Evidence — Gathered Safely

This is the heart of the file, and it must be gathered with care for people's safety. Document the **community harm** — the families, the homes, the livelihoods, the lack of alternatives, the disproportionate impact on the vulnerable that Amnesty and others have documented — and, for a project, the **environmental harm**. Draw on **human-rights monitors** — Amnesty International, the International Commission of Jurists, and others — whose reports on Swazi evictions carry weight abroad, and on **community testimony** gathered discreetly. Protect those who provide evidence, since speaking out here can bring harassment or worse. Credible, rights-referenced documentation is the single most powerful thing this file can contain, precisely because it can be taken to courts and bodies beyond the crown's control.

The Rights and External-Body Record

Document the rights and the routes, because these are the distinctive Eswatini levers. Gather the **constitutional and international rights** the harm violates — housing, property, due process, environment — and the record of how **the African Commission and other bodies** have treated comparable cases, since Swazi communities have engaged the African Commission over evictions before. Identify the **international pressure points** — donors, trade preferences, the regional and continental bodies, the Commonwealth. A community that can show a documented rights violation, and knows which external body has heard the like, holds leverage its captured domestic institutions deny it.

The Channels and Allies

Identify the channels and allies, safely. The **courts**, where they function, remain a real if uncertain domestic channel for land and eviction cases. The **African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights** and the regional and continental bodies are the distinctive external channel. **Human-rights monitors, international NGOs, the donors, and the Commonwealth** apply external pressure. The **unions, the constrained civil society, and above all the diaspora and solidarity networks** — especially in neighbouring South Africa

— can carry a case to safer ground. Map which apply, and which can be used safely, because in Eswatini the external channels reach where domestic ones are captured, and are far less dangerous to use.

The People — and Their Protection

Finally, map the human terrain, with safety foremost above every other consideration. Who is affected — the evicted families, the project's neighbours, the vulnerable? Who are the **unions**, the **few civil-society and human-rights groups**, the **sympathetic lawyers**, the **diaspora and solidarity networks**, the **international monitors and bodies**? And, crucially, **how are they protected** — from a state that has met dissent with harassment, detention, and lethal force? An Eswatini effort is advanced less by open domestic mobilisation, which is dangerous, than by a careful, protected coalition of the affected, the lawyers and monitors, and the external and diaspora allies who can press from safer ground — so map that coalition, and above all its protection, deliberately. A word on each of these allies, because their roles are distinctive and their handling delicate. The affected families supply the direct, credible testimony without which no court case or external communication has standing — but they must be protected, not exposed. The sympathetic lawyers supply access to the courts that still function, and a measure of legal shelter. The human-rights monitors supply documentation, credibility, and international reach, and can carry a case where a local voice would be endangered. And the diaspora and solidarity networks, especially across the border in South Africa, supply the safest ground of all — a place from which the case can be amplified and connected to international bodies without immediate risk to those still at home. No one of these is a mass domestic movement, and in Eswatini a mass domestic movement would be dangerous; together, carefully assembled and protected, they are the nearest and safest thing a Swazi effort has to real force.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Evidence does not move deciders by itself — but here, more than anywhere in this series, "opposition" must be understood with safety as the first and overriding concern, because Eswatini has met dissent with live fire, beatings, and death. What moves deciders here is rarely a public demonstration, which can be lethal, but an organised, documented community whose case is carried to courts and external bodies beyond the crown's reach. Eswatini offers little safe space for open confrontation; the task is to organise the community's stake into evidence and external leverage, and to protect its people at every step.

Why the Community Is Decisive — and Why It Must Be Protected

A court or an external body can act on a documented, organised community case; it can do little with an anonymous grievance. The community supplies what an effort runs on: the affected voices, the testimony, the evidence of harm and rights violation, and the legitimacy that makes a case credible before a court or the African Commission. But in Eswatini this community must be protected above all, because the state has answered dissent with violence. **A united community here is the effort's engine — but its power is best exercised through documentation, the courts, and external bodies, never through exposed protest that force has met with death.** This is the hardest and most important lesson in the whole guide, and it must be understood not as timidity but as the difference between an effort that protects people and one that gets them killed. The instinct to gather, to march, to make a visible stand is human and honourable, but in a state that answered the 2021 protests with live fire, that instinct can be fatal. A community that channels the same determination into documented testimony, a court application, and a submission to the African Commission achieves something a march cannot: it reaches decision-makers beyond the crown's reach, and it does so without offering the security forces a target. The measure of courage here is not visibility but effectiveness and survival — the patient, protected, external work that keeps a community both fighting and

alive. A community broken by force can no longer protect its land; one that survives, documents, and appeals abroad can keep seeking justice for years.

Finding the Affected Community

Begin with those the project or eviction touches most — the **families facing dispossession, the homesteads, the vulnerable widows and women and child-headed households** monitors have found most exposed — whose stake is direct and whose testimony is the heart of any case. Widen, carefully, to those who share the threat. Name the shared stake — **our homes, our land, our children's future** — but pursue it, for safety, through documentation and external appeal, not through open confrontation, because that is both safer and more likely to reach the bodies that can still act. There is a particular reason to centre the most vulnerable in this framing, and to do so with care. Monitors have found that widows, women, and child-headed households are both the most exposed to eviction and the least able to challenge it — which makes their protection the moral heart of the effort, but also means they must never be pushed to the exposed front of it. The task is to build the case around their documented plight, and to carry that case to the courts and the external bodies, while shielding the individuals themselves from the danger of visibility. Their stories, gathered with consent and care and told where necessary through monitors and lawyers rather than in exposed public confrontation, are among the most powerful evidence a Swazi effort can bring before the African Commission and the watching world.

Coalition-Building, Safely

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, but the Swazi coalition is built with protection foremost. Reach, carefully, to **sympathetic lawyers** who can take cases to court; **human-rights monitors** — Amnesty, the ICJ — who document and amplify; the **unions and constrained civil society**; and — decisively here — the **diaspora, regional solidarity networks, and international bodies** that can carry the case to safer ground beyond the crown's reach. Frame the coalition as a lawful, documented pursuit of rights and protection, and lean on the external allies to press what domestic actors cannot safely press. Breadth here means external reach and legal support far more than open local numbers.

Sustaining a Careful Effort

Eswatini efforts are constrained, dangerous, and can be slow, and sustaining them means sustaining both care and safety. Keep the community **informed, organised, and above all protected**; mark the safer steps — a court filing, a case documented, a petition to the African Commission, an international body engaged. And keep it **as safe as humanly possible**, because the state has met dissent with force, and no cause is worth a life needlessly lost; an effort that exposes its people to violence has failed them however just its cause. Prefer the legal, external, and documentary channels, which are both safer and more effective here, to any open confrontation. The effort that lasts is the one that stays organised, protected, and focused on the external levers that repression cannot reach. Sustaining such an effort demands a particular temperament, because its rewards are slow, external, and often invisible on the ground, while its dangers are immediate. There will rarely be the visible drama of a successful stand; there will be, instead, an eviction delayed by a court order, a case accepted by the African Commission, a monitor's report published abroad, a donor's quiet word to the authorities. A community that measures itself only by what changes visibly at home, or by a full stop to a project, will despair, because those are rare here. One that learns to value protection secured, records made, and external pressure slowly built — and that keeps its people safe while that pressure accumulates — can endure, and can hand a stronger, safer position to the next community. Endurance here is a matter of patient, protected, external persistence, and of the discipline never to trade a life for a gesture.

STEP 4: LEGAL, CUSTOMARY & INTERNATIONAL CHALLENGES — THE COURTS, THE LAND SYSTEM, AND THE HUMAN-RIGHTS BODIES

This is where an Eswatini effort is most realistically advanced — not through domestic protest, which can be deadly, but through the **courts where they still function, the rights that the land system violates, and above all the external human-rights bodies** that can hear a community the crown's institutions will not. Here the distinctive Eswatini levers are legal and external, and a community's task is to reach them, safely.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest, grave truth. The domestic levers are **captured and uncertain**: the Parliament and much of the system answer to the crown, and the courts, while they still hear land and eviction cases, are subservient and slow, shuffling challenges for years. The **external levers are stronger but slow and indirect**: the African Commission can find and pressure but not compel; international pressure moves slowly. What these levers realistically achieve is **protection, delay, redress, and external findings** — not usually a stop, and never at the cost of safety. Enter this front clear-eyed and safety-first: the courts and the external human-rights bodies are Eswatini's distinctive levers, strongest when the **harm is provable and the rights violation is clear** — but the realistic outcome is protection or a record, a stop is rare, and open domestic confrontation is dangerous.

The Courts and the Land System

The first front is the courts and the rights the land system violates. Insecure tenure and forced evictions without process are the clearest violations, and the **courts**, subservient though the system is, still hear land and eviction challenges — a real if uncertain channel that can win **delay, an order, or protection**. Work with **sympathetic lawyers** to bring the strongest procedural and rights-based challenge — lack of process, lack of alternative, violation of constitutional and international rights — because even a delay can protect families and buy time for the external levers. Be honest that the courts are captured and slow; but a court that halts an eviction, even temporarily, is real protection, and worth pursuing.

The African Commission and Regional Bodies

The second and distinctive front is external. The **African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights** can hear a Swazi community that its own institutions will not — Swazi communities have documented evictions and engaged the Commission before, at its sessions and through its commissioners. Bring the **documented rights violation** to the Commission and the regional and continental bodies, seeking findings, recommendations, and pressure the crown cannot simply silence. This external forum is the lever that most distinguishes an Eswatini effort, because it reaches over the head of a captured domestic system to a body bound by rights the community can invoke. Take the time to understand how the African Commission's process actually works, ideally with the help of a lawyer or an experienced human-rights organisation, because the details matter. The Commission generally expects that domestic remedies have been pursued or shown to be unavailable or ineffective — a bar that Eswatini's shuffled, endlessly delayed land cases can help meet. It can receive communications from affected communities and their representatives, conduct its own inquiries, issue findings and recommendations, and raise a matter at its sessions and through its commissioners, as Swazi communities have engaged it. A communication prepared to its requirements, with the rights violations set out clearly and the failure of domestic remedies documented, is one the Commission can take up; a vague complaint is easier to set aside.

International Pressure and the Diaspora

The third front is international leverage. **Donors, trade partners, the Commonwealth, the EU, and neighbouring states** hold pressure — aid, trade preferences, reputation — that the crown feels, and human-rights bodies and monitors have urged them to use it. The **diaspora and regional solidarity networks**, especially in South Africa, can carry a case to safer ground, amplify it, and connect it to international bodies. Pursued from the safer ground of external bodies, the diaspora, and the company's or investor's home country where a foreign investor is involved, these fronts are how a Swazi community reaches accountability that domestic capture and repression would otherwise foreclose — and reaches it without exposing its people to force. It is worth understanding why these legal and external fronts reinforce one another, because their combination is the heart of the Eswatini approach. The surviving courts generate the domestic legal record — the applications, the orders, the findings — that external bodies can build on, and can sometimes deliver immediate protection through an injunction. The African Commission and the regional bodies supply the external forum that is bound by rights the crown's institutions ignore, and that the crown cannot silence. International pressure supplies the diplomatic and economic leverage that makes the crown care about external findings. And the diaspora and monitors supply the safe ground and the amplification that carry it all beyond the borders. Each alone is limited: the courts are captured and slow, the Commission cannot compel, international pressure is indirect. But woven together — a court application for immediate protection, a communication to the African Commission for authoritative findings, international pressure to give those findings weight, all amplified safely from abroad — they form a web of external and legal accountability that reaches over a captured system, and reaches it without exposing the community to the force that domestic protest invites.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them — and here, above all, in the language of rights and in the safety of external forums. The same file of harm and rights violation becomes different arguments for a court, the African Commission, an international monitor, a donor, and the diaspora. Translate deliberately, and always with safety in mind.

For the Courts

The courts respond to **the law, the process, and the rights**. Frame the harm as a legal violation: the eviction without due process or alternative, the project approved without proper assessment, the breach of constitutional and international rights to housing, property, and environment. Give the court, through a lawyer, the documented violation and ask for an order or an injunction to halt or delay it. Make it easy to protect: *here is the right, here is the violation, here is the order sought*. Even a delay is real protection.

For the African Commission and Regional Bodies

The African Commission responds to **documented human-rights violations**. Frame the harm as a breach of the rights the African Charter protects — housing, property, due process, a healthy environment — as Swazi communities have framed their evictions before it. Give the Commission the documented violation and the failure of domestic remedies, and seek findings, recommendations, and pressure. This is the argument that reaches over a captured system to a body the crown cannot silence.

For International Monitors and Donors

Monitors and donors respond to **credible rights documentation and leverage**. Frame the harm as a documented pattern of violations — evictions, repression — that engages their mandates and their leverage:

aid, trade preferences, reputation. Give Amnesty, the ICJ, and the donors the evidence, so they can document, amplify, and press. Their reports and their leverage reach the crown from outside, where domestic voice cannot.

For the Diaspora and the World

The diaspora and international public respond to **injustice and clarity**. Translate the file into a story that is true and safe to tell: families dispossessed without recourse, a project harming a community, under a system that answers to no one at home. Put the human harm first, frame it as a rights violation, and carry it to safer ground abroad. Keep it scrupulously accurate; before courts and international bodies, overstatement discredits, and in a small country, exposure endangers — so protect the people in every telling.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, and never expose your people needlessly. Your credibility is your greatest asset before a court and the African Commission, and your people's safety is more important than any argument or any project. State the harm precisely, measure it against rights accurately, and pursue it through the safest effective channel. A community that is precise, credible, and careful — especially about rights and safety — is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches, and far safer than one that confronts.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — but in Eswatini, that pressure works best when it reaches beyond the borders, and domestic media must be used with the greatest care in a repressive environment where speaking out brings danger. The story — families dispossessed, a project harming a community, under an absolute monarchy — is one that travels, and travels most safely, abroad.

Why Media Matters — Especially Abroad

A crown conscious of its international standing, and donors and neighbours watching, behave differently when rights violations are visible internationally. Media does three things here: it **informs and moves the international bodies, donors, and diaspora**, it **raises the reputational and diplomatic cost** to the crown, and it **draws the international attention** that domestic repression cannot silence. Because domestic media is constrained and domestic dissent dangerous, international and diaspora media are unusually powerful and far safer levers, reaching where the domestic press cannot and where the speaker is beyond immediate reach. A violation made visible to the world is one the crown cannot simply bury. This is why the international, regional, and diaspora press deserve particular emphasis in an Eswatini effort. The crown operates its harshest measures most freely when they are unseen beyond the borders, and that invisibility is part of what allows evictions and repression to proceed. Bringing a documented, credible account of the harm to an international and regional audience — to the South African press next door, to the diaspora networks, to the human-rights media — collapses the distance that protected it, and forces the crown to answer, before donors and neighbours and the wider world, for conduct it preferred to keep hidden at home. Cultivate these external outlets with accuracy and care, and with unwavering attention to the safety of those still inside the country, because their reach turns a hidden Swazi injustice into an international matter the crown must manage.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the human harm and the rights violation. The strongest frame is concrete and rights-based: *families are being dispossessed without process or recourse — a violation of their rights — under a system*

that offers them no appeal at home. Put the human harm first, the rights violation close behind, and let the wider context follow, because that framing engages the international bodies and the sympathetic world. Keep it scrupulously accurate; before international bodies and a watching world, overstatement is caught and discredits the case, and in a small country, careless exposure endangers real people.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to safety above all. **International media, regional (especially South African) media, and diaspora networks** for the reach and the pressure that travel safely; **human-rights monitors' reports** for documented, credible amplification; the **African Commission and international bodies** for authoritative findings; and the **domestic press only with the greatest care**, given its constraints and the grave risks to those who speak. Because Eswatini's captured system answers most to external pressure, the international, regional, and diaspora channels are the ones that matter most — and are by far the safest.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, credible, and safe — the goal is external pressure and protection, not a domestic confrontation that force could meet with violence. Protect individuals above all, in a state that has shot, beaten, and detained those who dissent; prefer collective, external, and documentary voice to any exposed local spokesperson who could be targeted, and never publish what could identify people to their danger. Handle the crown and the authorities factually, not with invective, because credibility before international bodies depends on it and safety may depend on it too. And sustain the effort patiently, because external pressure moves slowly. Above all, let the harm and the rights violation, carried safely to the world, do the work — because that is where an Eswatini effort is both most effective and least dangerous.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real harm, and the real facts, keep it factual, and protect those involved above all. Here precision about rights, and safety, matter more than force.

8A: Requesting Information (Project or Eviction)

Subject: Request for information — [project/eviction] at [location]

Dear [official/authority],

I write on behalf of [community/group] regarding [project/eviction] at [location]. To understand and respond to the decisions affecting our homes and land, we respectfully request the **relevant permits, notices, and orders**, the **process followed**, information on the **land and families affected**, and any **assessment** conducted. We wish to ensure our rights and proper process are respected.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8B: Instructing a Lawyer (Court Challenge)

Subject: Request for legal assistance — [eviction/project]

Dear [lawyer/legal-aid organisation],

Our community at [location] faces [eviction/harm] from [project/authority], apparently without [due process / adequate alternative / lawful order], in violation of our rights to [housing/property/due process]. We seek assistance to challenge this in the courts, and to seek an order to halt or delay it. We have documentation — notices, testimony, photographs — and can provide it. Might you assist us, or refer us to those who can?

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: Submission to the African Commission

Subject: Communication regarding rights violations at [location], Eswatini

To the African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights,

We, [community/group], submit this communication regarding [eviction/project] at [location], which violates our rights to [housing/property/due process/environment] under the African Charter, and for which domestic remedies have proven [unavailable/ineffective/exhausted]. We attach documentation of the harm and the violation, and respectfully seek the Commission's findings, recommendations, and engagement. We ask that the safety of those named be protected.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: Letter to a Human-Rights Monitor

Subject: Documented rights violations at [location] — request for attention

Dear [Amnesty / ICJ / organisation],

Our community at [location] faces [eviction/harm] in violation of our rights, part of the pattern of [forced evictions / repression] your organisation has documented in Eswatini. We can provide testimony, notices, and evidence, gathered with care for people's safety. We respectfully seek your documentation, amplification, and support. Please advise how we may share our evidence securely.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: Appeal to the Diaspora / Solidarity Network

Subject: Support for a community facing [eviction/project] in Eswatini

Dear friends and compatriots,

Our community at [location] faces [eviction/harm], with little recourse at home. We ask your help to carry our case to safer ground — to international bodies, media, and donors — and to amplify it beyond the borders, as only those abroad can safely do. Please help us document, share, and press this case, while protecting the safety of those still at home.

In solidarity,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: Letter to a Donor or International Body

Subject: Rights violations at [location] — a call to use your leverage

Dear [donor / embassy / Commonwealth / body],

We write regarding [eviction/project] at [location] in Eswatini, which violates the rights of [families/community], part of a documented pattern. We respectfully ask you to raise this with the authorities and to use your leverage — aid, trade, diplomacy — to press for protection and redress, as human-rights bodies have urged. We can provide documentation and request that the safety of those involved be protected.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Letter to a Union

Subject: Standing together on [project/eviction]

Dear [union],

Our community, and workers affected by [project/eviction], share a stake in how people and land are treated at [location]. We have documented [harm — community, environmental, labour], with care for safety. We hope to work with you to press, safely and through lawful and external channels, for protection and accountability. Might we meet, carefully, to discuss a common approach?

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8H: Informing the Community (Carefully)

Subject: Our homes and land — and how we can seek help safely

Dear neighbours,

[Project/eviction] threatens our [homes/land/livelihoods]. We know that open protest here has been met with force, so we are seeking help through safer, stronger channels — the courts, human-rights bodies abroad, and those who can press from outside. Please share, carefully and safely, what you know and what has happened to you, so that together we can seek protection and justice — without exposing anyone to danger. Your safety comes first.

With respect and care,

[Name, community group]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a project or eviction is moving fast — an order imminent, bulldozers near — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and safest here, which means an urgent court application, a human-rights monitor, and documentation.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials — safely: **what the project or eviction is, what harm it would do, who is behind it, and what process was followed.** Identify the immediate channel — an **urgent court application to halt an eviction, a notice period, a monitor who can act now** — because that is what you must reach first. Contact **a lawyer and a human-rights monitor** at once, because in Eswatini an urgent court order and an external monitor are the fastest and safest routes to protection, as against exposed protest, which force can meet with violence.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others here, though none is certain. **An urgent court application** can seek to halt an eviction immediately. **A documented rights violation sent to a human-rights monitor** can trigger fast external attention. **An alert to the diaspora and international media** draws attention repression cannot silence. **A rapid submission to a regional body** can begin external engagement. These legal and external levers outpace — and are far safer than — domestic protest, which force can meet with live fire in hours.

Emergency Coalition-Building — Safely

You cannot build a broad coalition overnight, and open domestic mobilisation is dangerous. But you can activate a fast, safer one: the **affected families' documented testimony, a lawyer, a human-rights monitor, and a diaspora or international contact.** A handful of protected voices carrying a documented violation to a court and an external body, at the right moment, is the most a rapid Eswatini effort can safely do — and often the most that can protect people at all. Speed favours the prepared: know your harm, your rights, your lawyer, your external contact, and your people's safety before the deadline.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is not merely tilted but concentrated — an absolute monarchy in which the Parliament, the courts, the chiefs, and the land itself answer, in the end, to the crown, and in which open dissent has been met with lethal force. This is Eswatini's central, honest truth, and the whole guide has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the field is level here would be both false and dangerous.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are the ordinary structure of the state. **Power is concentrated in the crown**, to which the institutions are subservient. **Land is held in trust by the King** and allocated by chiefs loyal to him, leaving residents insecure. **Dissent has been met with force** — the 2021 protests with live fire and death, activists with harassment and detention. **Legal challenges are shuffled and delayed** for years. This is not a tilt a domestic movement can overpower, and open confrontation invites violence; it is the structure an effort here must be built for, which is why this guide leans so heavily on the external levers and on safety.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is concentrated and domestic space is captured and dangerous, take the effort to where the system can still be reached: **the courts that survive, and above all outside the country.** Lean on the **surviving courts**, the **African Commission and regional bodies**, **international pressure**, and the **diaspora** — the levers that reach in from outside and that repression cannot silence. Aim realistically at **protection, delay, redress, and external findings**, which are achievable, rather than at a stop, which is rare. Protect your people by preferring these legal, external, and documentary channels to any exposed domestic protest. And build the record even when you cannot win, because a documented violation lodged

with an external body raises the cost of the next, and builds the case for change. A concentrated field here does not so much lengthen the odds as move the fight to the courts and abroad — and there a Swazi community's real, if narrow, power lies.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may well lose, and this guide will not pretend otherwise — here, losing is a likely outcome, as the evictions that proceeded and the protests met with force attest. If the project or eviction proceeds, the work is still not wasted: the **harm was documented, the rights violation lodged with those who can act, the record made, and the next effort — and the slow external pressure for change — starts a little stronger**. External accountability is incremental; each documented violation raises the cost and builds the case. Fight, safely and lawfully, to protect your people and hold the system to the rights it violates; if you lose, lose in a way that leaves an external record and, above all, keeps your people alive and safe.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO HOLDS THE POWER

In Eswatini, the question is less one of hidden corruption than of openly concentrated power and wealth — a system in which, monitors note, the royal family lives lavishly while roughly two-thirds of Swazis live below the poverty line, and in which land, minerals, and institutions are bound up with the crown. This must be approached factually and with great care, because in an absolute monarchy, challenging how power and resources are held carries real danger.

Telling Concentration from Ordinary Governance

A system in which power and resources are concentrated in the crown is not a matter of a few corrupt officials to be exposed; it is the openly acknowledged structure of the state, and treating it as ordinary graft would both misread it and, in confronting it directly, endanger those who do. The marks here are structural: **land and minerals bound to the crown, institutions subservient to it, patronage through the chiefs, and wealth concentrated amid widespread poverty**. Be rigorous and factual, and be careful: describe the structure accurately and without invective, and pursue the specific harm to your community — the eviction, the project — rather than mounting a direct, dangerous challenge to the system itself, which is a matter for the nation's own long political processes, not for a community fighting to keep its land.

Responding to Concentrated Power — Carefully

Where power is concentrated and domestic remedies captured, the response is external and legal, pursued safely. Take the **documented harm and rights violation** to the **courts that still function** and to the **African Commission and international bodies**, which can address a specific violation without requiring a dangerous domestic confrontation with the crown itself. Use **international pressure** — donors, trade, the region — which reaches the concentration of power from outside. Rely on **monitors, the diaspora, and international bodies** to carry what is dangerous to carry at home. Keep the focus on your community's specific harm and rights, documented and taken to external forums, rather than on a frontal challenge to a system that has met such challenges with force.

A Note on Safety and Care

This is the guide's most important note, and it governs everything here. Eswatini has met dissent with live fire, beatings, detention, and death — the gravest danger in this whole series — and pursuing any of this carries real risk to life and liberty. So keep the effort **documentary, legal, external, collective, and above**

all protected. Prefer the courts and the external bodies, which are both safer and stronger, to any exposed domestic action. Protect individuals absolutely — never let a single named person carry a public burden that could make them a target; use collective, external, and diaspora voice instead. Seek the protection of human-rights monitors and international bodies, which can shield those at risk. Safety here is not caution at the expense of the cause; it is the first duty of the cause, because no eviction resisted and no project stopped is worth a life, and because a community that survives, protected, can keep seeking justice — while one that is broken by force cannot.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others. Here is how they fit into a single, careful, safety-first effort in Eswatini.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together, carefully. **Documentation** builds the harm-and-rights-violation file. **Target identification** aims it at the deciders and the channels. **Local opposition** organises the community's stake, safely and protected. **Legal, customary, and international** work presses the courts, the African Commission, and international pressure. **Media** carries it, safely, beyond the borders. The harm and the rights violation feed all five at once — a documented violation is evidence for a court, a submission to the African Commission, a report for a monitor, and a story for the diaspora together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, where the strongest levers are external and the domestic space is dangerous, they must reach outward together and safely. The compounding matters especially in Eswatini, because no single lever is strong enough to rely on and the domestic ones are perilous besides. Consider how a single documented eviction — families put off their land without process or alternative — travels across all the fronts at once: it is, in the same period, the basis of an urgent court application, a communication to the African Commission, a case for a human-rights monitor's report, a matter for a donor's diplomatic pressure, and a story the diaspora can carry to international media. A community pursuing only one of these, especially only a domestic and exposed one, would likely see it absorbed, delayed, or met with force; a community pursuing all of them together makes the violation impossible to bury on every side at once, and shifts the fight to the external and legal ground where it is both safer and stronger. In a system this captured and this dangerous, that mutual reinforcement across external fronts is not a refinement but the whole survivable strategy.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the project or eviction, the harm, the rights violation, and the deciders; document safely; find a lawyer and identify the external channels and allies. **Middle (months 2–12):** build the protected case and coalition; file in the courts; submit to the African Commission and the monitors; enlist international and diaspora pressure. **Later (months and years):** press the courts and external processes for protection, redress, and findings, and build the record whatever the outcome. An Eswatini effort is patient, external, and often slow, and its likeliest fruit is protection or a record rather than a stop; pace the effort, and one's hopes, accordingly — and keep safety foremost, always.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm and the rights violation credibly; reach the courts and the external bodies — the African Commission, the**

monitors, the donors, the region — the captured system cannot suppress; protect your people above all; and keep every claim precise. The community that presses all five, safely and lawfully, gives itself the narrow but real chance that Eswatini's captured system still allows — to win protection, delay, redress, external findings, and rarely a stop — while holding, throughout, to the honest truths that there is no grassroots precedent, that domestic protest can be deadly, and that no cause is worth a life.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive project or an eviction in Eswatini is genuinely difficult and genuinely dangerous — the hardest and most hazardous case in this whole series — and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: there is no grassroots victory to point to, dissent has been met with lethal force, and the institutions answer to the crown. And yet the effort is not without hope, because even an absolute monarchy sits within a region and a world of courts, human-rights bodies, watching donors, and neighbours — and those external levers, together with the courts that still function, are real, reachable, and far safer than confronting the crown at home.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The external levers — the African Commission, the region, the donors, the diaspora — and the surviving courts are the real ones, and they reach where the crown's captured institutions cannot silence them. A documented rights violation is the community's strongest weapon. But the domestic space is captured and dangerous, dissent has been met with death, and the likeliest outcome is protection or a record, not a stop.** Hold both truths at once: real, external, reachable levers, and honestly grave and hazardous conditions.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the safety — that give these efforts their force. Document the harm and the rights violation. Reach the courts, the African Commission, the monitors, and the donors. Protect your people above every other consideration, and prefer the safer external and legal channels to any exposed protest. And keep every claim precise, because before a court and the African Commission, credibility is everything — and for a Swazi community, safety is everything, and more.

Families in communities like Velezizweni and Ntondozi have faced eviction with nowhere to go; the 2021 protests were met with live fire and death; legal challenges have been shuffled and delayed for years; and the projects and evictions have too often proceeded. This guide has hidden none of it. But Swazi communities have also documented their evictions and carried them to the African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights — reaching, over the head of a captured system, a body bound by rights the community can invoke — and human-rights monitors and neighbours and donors are watching. There, at the courts that still function and the external bodies beyond the crown's reach, a Swazi community has leverage that domestic capture cannot deny it and repression cannot silence. There is no easy victory to promise you, no grassroots precedent to inherit, and no path here that is free of danger; no path here that is wholly free of danger; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted on safety above all. But your homes, your land, and your children's future are worth defending, the rights the system violates are real and can be invoked abroad, and the careful, documented, external, and above all safe effort to seek protection and redress is one worth making — so long as it keeps your people alive. The power here lies in the courts that survive and in the world beyond the borders. Reach it carefully, protect your people always, and you reach the one real leverage a Swazi community holds. That leverage is not nothing. A captured domestic system that answers to no one at home still answers, in part, to a region and a world that watch — to a continental human-rights body bound by a charter the community can invoke, to donors and trade partners the crown cannot afford to ignore, to neighbours across an open border, and to courts that, however slow, can still order an eviction halted. Every one of those is a handle a community can grasp from ground the crown cannot fully control.

Grasp them carefully, document meticulously, protect your people without exception, and press patiently through the courts and the bodies beyond the borders, and you will have done, for your homes and your land, the most that can honestly and safely be done in Eswatini — and kept your people alive to keep seeking justice.